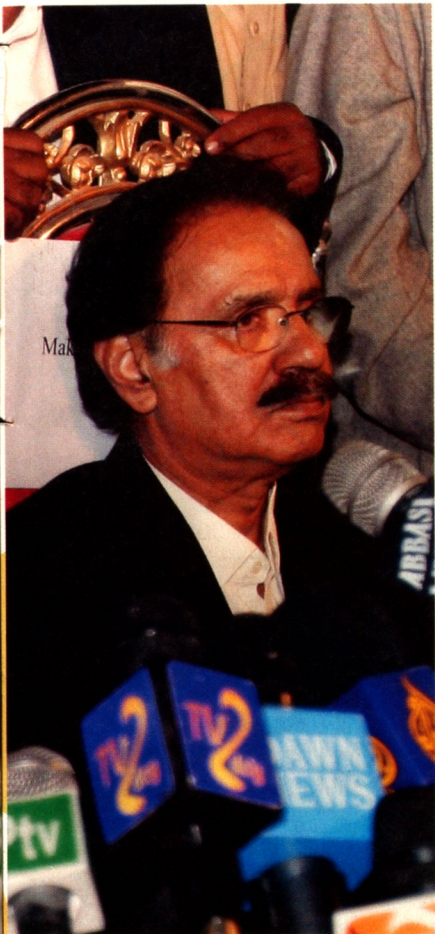


AP PHOTOS/SHAKIL ADIL



HEIR APPARENT: Bilawal (centre) was made head of the party, while Zardari (left) is the regent

inadvertently come out of the killing of one of Pakistan's most charismatic leaders. The sight of the erstwhile foes coming together in a moment of crisis and tragedy—deeply troubling for their now common rivals, former ruling Pakistan Muslim League (PML)—did come as a form of healing touch for traumatised Pakistanis.

Though Pakistani Election Commission's (EC) decision to postpone the polls scheduled for January 8 till February 18, is on expected lines, it is likely to plunge the country into further uncertainty. President Musharraf tried to justify the decision by citing the destruction of the commission's offices and election paraphernalia in several parts of the country, particularly in Sindh, as well as unrest in parts of North-West Frontier Province, his explanations have few takers. Many believe the postponement has taken place because the establishment fears that a sympathy wave for PPP—and by extension for Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz) (PMLN)—would rout PML. In the chaos that followed the

assassination, the main target of the protesters' ire was the pro-Musharraf PML. It was evident from the anxious faces of the former ruling party's leaders that they dreaded public sentiment turning against them in the polls, and had, in fact, called for the elections to be postponed. PPP and PMLN have, meanwhile, gone on the warpath, condemning the delay which they say is simply "an attempt to provide the establishment more time to rig the polls." Both parties, however, have stated they will take part under protest.

The lack of popular belief in the government's explanations, that only the logistical inability of EC to conduct the polls is the cause of the postponement, is understandable. General Musharraf's appointed caretaker Government has lost credibility after its handling of Bhutto's assassination. Like most political assassinations, conspiracy theories about the people behind it are ruling the roost. But the Government has not done itself any service with the way it has tackled some basic aspects of the tragic incident. It has continued to assert that Bhutto died after hitting her head on a lever of her bullet-and-bomb-proof



Bhutto's death has turned popular sentiment resolutely against President Musharraf



car's sunroof even before all the facts have been ascertained, and even in the face of compelling video footage that indicates that she probably died from gunshot wounds before a suicide bomber blew himself up nearby. It failed to carry out a mandatory autopsy citing Zardari's refusal to allow it, even though it did not need his permission to conduct it. The place where the attack took place was washed with fire hoses soon after the dead and injured had been evacuated, which destroyed any evidence that may have aided forensic experts. And, the Government has refused to acknowledge a serious breach of security that allowed the assassin to come within striking distance of the slain leader.

No doubt the decision to wave at her

BACK TO THE WALL: Musharraf's credibility drops to an all time low